C19W10 · THURSDAY, APRIL 2, 2026

GROWTH DISCUSSION + AI FOR YOUR PRODUCT

Feedback. What AI can do.

USER COUNT LEADERBOARD

Week 2. Update your numbers.

Sift	–	Vouch	–	QuestCity	–	Rekindled	0
Roam	0	Circles	0	FreeWeight	0	Recruitr	3
Misfit AI	0	Evidence of Life	–	NoticeMe	–	Std. Deviants	0

AUTOMATE THE LEADERBOARD

I don't want to ask you for numbers every class.

You build the API endpoint.

I pull your numbers automatically before each class. No manual reporting.

YOUR API ENDPOINT

Build a public endpoint that returns JSON:

```
GET https://your-app.com/api/metrics

{
  "signups": 42,
  "active_users": 15,
  "waitlist": 147,
  "page_views": 820
}
```

WHAT EACH METRIC MEANS

signups: registered accounts in your database

active_users: users who did something meaningful (you define what)

waitlist: email signups before the product is live

page_views: from GA4 or your analytics tool

Return 0 for any metric you don't have yet. That's fine.

PUT YOUR URL IN GITHUB

Add this file to your repo root:

```
// 20260402_api-metrics.md

https://your-app.com/api/metrics
```

That's it. One file, one URL. Commit and push. I'll grab it automatically.

REQUIREMENTS

- **Public** — no auth required (it's just aggregate counts)
- **Returns JSON** — with the four metric fields
- **Always up** — if it's down when I check, you get zeroes on the board
- **Counts real users** — from your database, not hardcoded

YOUR GROWTH STRATEGIES

A GOOD STRATEGY IS SPECIFIC

Named channels with numbers

"r/AskNYC (2.1M members)" or "Instagram DMs to NYC food bloggers with 5k-50k followers."

The actual words you'll say

Draft the DM. The Reddit post. The caption. Not "we'll post about our product."

A GOOD STRATEGY HAS NUMBERS

Volume commitments

"10 DMs per day for 5 days = 50 touches."

A plan without numbers is a wish.

Measurement

How will you know which channel is working?

If analytics can't track it, add a "how did you hear about us?" field.

FOR THIS WEEK: SPEED MATTERS

Direct outreach — DMs, cold emails, texts	**Fast + free**
Community posts — Reddit, Discord, WhatsApp groups	**Fast + free**
Content / SEO — TikTok, blog posts, Instagram	Slower, but builds credibility
Paid ads — Google, Meta, Reddit	Fast if you have the means

YOU'D PROBABLY IGNORE THIS

Inbox noise

"Hey! We built an amazing app that revolutionizes how you discover events in NYC! Check it out at [link] and sign up for free! Let me know what you think!"

- All about them, nothing about you
- Generic — could be sent to anyone
- Asks for everything upfront

YOU MIGHT ACTUALLY READ THIS

Feels personal

"I saw your post about finding things to do this weekend — I'm a Columbia student building a tool that curates NYC events based on your vibe. Would you be willing to try it and tell me if it sucks? Takes 2 min."

- References something specific about you
- Honest about what it is
- Small ask with a clear time commitment

START AN INSPIRATION FOLDER

When a cold email, DM, or LinkedIn message actually gets you to pay attention, save it.

Screenshot it. Copy the text. Drop it in a folder.

When it's time to write your own outreach, open that folder. The best templates come from messages that actually worked on you.

Bonus: if you keep these as text (not just screenshots), you can feed the whole folder to an LLM and ask it to help you write outreach in that style.

"I'M A COLUMBIA STUDENT BUILDING X"

This gets a higher response rate than pretending to be a company.
People are generous with students. Use it.

PATTERNS I'M SEEING

YOU'RE LISTENING TO USERS. KEEP GOING.

Several teams are getting real feedback and responding with real changes. That's exactly how this is supposed to work.

Next step: make sure every build item traces back to something a user told you. If you have clear signal, follow it.

SHARP FOCUS IS WORKING

The teams making the most progress have picked one audience and gone deep.

If you're serving two audiences right now, that's OK. But consider: which one do you double down on first? Get traction with one group. Then expand.

SMART THINKING ON NETWORK DENSITY

50

people who all know each other

Product feels alive

1,000

strangers

Might still feel empty

Target **dense clusters of connected people**. Friend groups, teams, communities that already talk to each other.

YOU'RE ATTACKING THE COLD START PROBLEM

Several of you have products that need other people to be valuable. You're finding ways to deal with it.

Seed one side first — get athletes in to build a robust presence before bringing coaches at scale

Network density — make the product work for one small, tight group before scaling up

Wizard of Oz — do it manually behind the curtain until you have enough users to justify building it for real

SOME OF THOSE WIZARD OF OZ MOMENTS CAN BE LLM CALLS

If you're doing something manually behind the curtain, ask: could an LLM do this?

Generating personalized recommendations? Summarizing user data? Drafting a weekly recap? These don't need a full engineering effort. A well-prompted API call might get you 80% of the way there.

SOME OF YOUR GROWTH STRATEGIES ARE REALLY GOOD

Channel-by-channel breakdowns. Specific daily targets. Drafted outreach copy. Influencer strategies with the right approach. Strong work.

One thing to watch: make sure your targets are realistic. Better to commit to numbers you'll actually hit than to write aspirational numbers that slip.

PRIORITIZE YOUR ROADMAP

Some of you are shipping fast. That's great. But are you shipping the **right things in the right order**?

Try RICE scoring: Reach, Impact, Confidence, Effort. Rank your backlog so you're making deliberate decisions about what to build next, not just picking whatever feels right.

SOME "HARD" FEATURES ARE ACTUALLY QUICK

Calendar integrations. Photo imports. Weekly recap emails. These feel like big projects, but with current tools they're often a day or two of work.

If something is on your roadmap as a multi-week item, challenge that assumption. Can you sprint through it this week?

CHECK YOUR COURSEWORKS MESSAGES

I've reviewed your roadmaps and growth plans and sent team-specific feedback on Courseworks.

Read it as a team. If you have questions or want to dig deeper on anything, come talk to me.

DON'T LET BOTTLENECKS HAPPEN ON YOUR TEAM.

THE TOOLS MAKE THIS ACCESSIBLE TO EVERYONE

Lovable, Cursor, Claude Code. Non-engineers are shipping real features.

Multiple people on your team should be able to demo the product on a moment's notice.

At the very least, your product should be **live and public online** somewhere.

STRONG DEMAND SIGNALS IN THIS CLASS

Some teams have real demand numbers already. **147 waitlist signups.** That's great.

Next challenge: converting that interest into active users. Signups are a promise. The product has to deliver. Plan the conversion workflow now.

USE YOUR NETWORK TO EXPAND

If your product targets a specific community, your first users are people you already know. But don't stop there.

Your users know people you don't. Coach to other coaches. Athletes at other schools. It's intimidating to make these asks but it's good to make that leap and learn what works and what doesn't. You may need to provide a professional looking proposal or product demo video to get interest.

CROSS-POLLINATE

Part of the value of a studio class is having other teams to share knowledge with, learn from, and critique. Someone in this room has already solved your problem.

Example: Standard Deviants built 20+ API integrations in their first week. If you're working on integrations, ask them how they did it.

COMPARISONS TO EXISTING PRODUCTS ARE A GOOD SIGN

If people compare you to something they already know, that means they understand what you do. Lean into it. Then be **significantly better**.

"What if Google Timeline were a scrapbook?"
"What if Notion were automated?"

AI FOR YOUR PRODUCT

LLMS AREN'T JUST CHATBOTS.

Chatbots are one pattern. There are five or six others that are more useful for most of you.

TURN UNSTRUCTURED DATA INTO STRUCTURED DATA

User writes a paragraph. AI extracts clean, structured fields.

Input

"I'm looking for something fun to do Saturday night in the East Village, maybe live music, under $30"

Output

```
{ neighborhood: "East Village",
category: "live music",
price_max: 30,
date: "Saturday" }
```

CLASSIFY, SORT, AND ROUTE

AI looks at content and puts it in the right bucket. No conversation needed.

Events: classify by vibe, genre, audience (Sift, HAUNT)

User feedback: route bug reports vs feature requests vs complaints

Content moderation: flag inappropriate content before it's visible (Rekindled, Circles)

LET AI DECIDE, LET CODE EXECUTE

The LLM figures out **what** to do. Your code **does** it. This is called tool use or function calling.

AI brain

"User wants events in Brooklyn this weekend under $20"

→

Code hands

search_events(location="Brooklyn", date="weekend", max_price=20)

DECISION SUPPORT, NOT DECISIONS

AI recommends. Human (or simple rules) decides.

≥ 85%	60-84%	< 60%
Auto-execute	Queue for review	Escalate to human

LLMS CAN APPROXIMATE ALGORITHMS YOU DON'T HAVE DATA FOR

A proper recommendation engine needs tons of training data. You don't have that yet.

An LLM can approximate recommendations with just a few examples and a well-designed prompt. It won't be as good as a trained model at scale, but it's **good enough to ship today**.

Give the LLM a few examples of good matches, describe the criteria, and let it

ALWAYS KEEP A HUMAN IN THE LOOP.

AI generates. Human reviews. Human approves.
Every successful AI product follows this pattern.

WHAT'S NEXT

DUE TUESDAY, APRIL 7

Track A: User Testing Sessions

3-5 sessions on your onboarding flow.

Synthesis + product recommendation: what did you learn? What are you changing?

DUE THURSDAY, APRIL 9

Track B: 20+ Real Users + Growth Doc Part 2

Drive traffic. Collect funnel data.

Report what worked and what didn't.

FEATURE FREEZE: APRIL 23.

Three weeks. After that: data collection and pitch prep only.
The users you get NOW are the data you present at Demo Day.

TEAM PRESENTATIONS

Starting next week: 2 teams present per class. ~10 min each.

DATE	CLASS	TEAM 1	TEAM 2
Tue, Apr 7	c20		
Thu, Apr 9	c21	the birds	
Tue, Apr 14	c22	FreeWeight	Vouch
Thu, Apr 16	c23	Std Deviants	MisFitAI
Tue, Apr 21	c24	4CUz	j-combinators
Thu, Apr 23	c25	Millionaires	Recruitr

Format

5 min present, 5 min feedback. Show the product live. Walk through your data.

This is not Demo Day

Practice + feedback. Show what's real, where you're stuck. Demo Day polish comes later.

USER COUNT LEADERBOARD — LIVE

Let's see those endpoints.

Sift —	Vouch —	QuestCity —	Rekindled —
Roam —	Circles —	FreeWeight —	Recruitr —
Misfit AI —	Evidence of Life —	NoticeMe —	Std. Deviants —

GET USERS. SHIP AI THAT HELPS THEM.

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